

Peer review should work for scientists

An open letter on independent, compensated peer review

September 30, 2026

Dear colleagues,

Every year, science spends very large sums on publishing: subscriptions, article processing charges, institutional agreements. Yet the step that gives a published paper its value, careful evaluation by other experts, is mostly carried out for free. Researchers review in the evenings, between grant deadlines, teaching and their own experiments. They do it because they believe in it.

That goodwill is under growing strain. The number of papers keeps rising, while the number of people with the time and expertise to review them does not. Editors often need many invitations before two reviewers accept, and manuscripts can wait for months. And when reviewers do say yes, many cannot give the work the attention it deserves, precisely because it is unpaid and has to fit around everything else.

None of this requires a villain. Journals, editors and reviewers are mostly doing their best inside a system that grew up in a different era. But the result is a structure in which the people who provide the essential intellectual labour are neither paid for it nor have any say in the infrastructure that depends on it. Scientists already provide the expertise that makes peer review possible. We think they should also have a voice in how it is run, and be paid for their time.

We are not the first to think about this, and we do not want to repeat old mistakes. Over the past fifteen years, two ideas have been tested separately.

The first is paying reviewers, and the evidence so far is encouraging. In a field experiment with around 1,500 referees at the *Journal of Public Economics*, a \$100 payment for meeting a deadline shortened reviews by about eight days, without lowering their quality and without reducing referees' later willingness to review for free.¹ At *Critical Care Medicine*, reviewers offered \$250 completed more reviews (50% versus 42%) with no difference in quality.² Since 2025, *Biology Open* has paid reviewers £220 per manuscript, conditional on a timely review of adequate quality, and reports first decisions in a median of five working days, against 31 under its conventional process.³ Payment is not a miracle cure, but it helps, especially when combined with clear deadlines and quality standards.

The second is review independent of journals, and its history is more mixed and more instructive. Services that sold independent review to individual authors, such as Rubriq and Axios Review, closed around 2017: authors would not pay, and journals often re-reviewed the work anyway.⁴ By contrast, initiatives that secured agreements with journals in advance have worked. At Review Commons, partner journals did not re-review 86% of the papers they went on to accept,⁵ and Peer Community In now recommends preprints that more than a hundred journals will consider on the basis of its reviews.⁶ Researcher-governed models such as these, and SciPost, show that the community can run high-quality evaluation. They also show the risk: SciPost reported in 2025 that only about one in nine organisations benefiting from its work had ever

¹R. Chetty, E. Saez and L. Sándor, "What policies increase prosocial behavior? An experiment with referees at the *Journal of Public Economics*", *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 28(3), 2014.

²"Monetary incentives for peer review at a medical journal: a quasi-randomized experimental study", International Congress on Peer Review and Scientific Publication, <https://peerreviewcongress.org/abstract/monetary-incentives-for-peer-review-at-a-medical-journal-a-quasi-randomized-experimental-study>.

³Gorelick et al., evaluation of *Biology Open*'s paid "Fast & Fair" review, bioRxiv, 2026 (non-randomised comparison), <https://www.biorxiv.org/content/10.64898/2026.06.02.729548v1>.

⁴*The Scholarly Kitchen*, 25 September 2017, <https://scholarlykitchen.sspnet.org/2017/09/25/portable-peer-review-rip/>.

⁵ASAPbio, <https://asapbio.org/review-commons-9-months/>.

⁶Peer Community In, highlights of 2025, <https://peercommunityin.org/2026/01/14/pci-and-peer-community-journal-highlights-of-2025>.

contributed to funding it.⁷

The lesson we draw is simple. Independent, paid peer review can work, but only as shared infrastructure, funded by institutions and recognised by journals and funders from the start. It cannot work as a product sold to individual authors.

We therefore want to find out, together with the scientific community, whether a scientist-owned co-operative for independent peer review can fill this gap. Reviewers would be paid for their time and expertise, whether their assessment is positive or negative, so that payment never depends on the verdict. Researchers would be members, and would help decide on governance, review standards, compensation and transparency. Reviews would become a lasting record attached to the work, with its versions, reports and author responses, and with consent they could be public and portable instead of disappearing when a manuscript moves to another journal. The aim is to complement journals, not to replace them: journals could use these reviews, as could authors, readers, funders and hiring committees.

The obvious first question is where the money would come from. Our answer is: from those who already rely on peer review and would benefit from making it faster, more reliable and more transparent. That means universities and research institutes, research funders, learned societies and, potentially, journals and publishers. Instead of paying for evaluation indirectly and invisibly through publishing costs, they could support it directly as shared infrastructure, and that money would reach the people doing the work.

There are signs that funders are open to this. Several have begun to prioritise preprints and open review, and in 2025 the US National Institutes of Health consulted on allowing higher publication costs for journals that pay reviewers and publish their reports.⁸ At the same time, an opaque market is emerging: a recent investigation found around a thousand job advertisements offering reviewers €30 to €40 per review through undisclosed intermediaries.⁹ We believe fair, transparent and accountable paid review, governed by scientists, is a better answer. Scientific judgement must remain independent of money: those who fund the cooperative would support the infrastructure, not individual decisions, and would have no influence on any assessment.

This is an early-stage initiative. There is no finished service yet and no partners to announce. That is deliberate: we would rather design this with the people who will do the reviewing than present it to them ready-made. We are looking for researchers willing to review through the network or to help design how it works; editors and journals interested in using independent reviews; universities, libraries, funders and learned societies willing to explore supporting shared review infrastructure; and, above all, critics. If you think this cannot work, we want to hear why.

One question matters most to us: what would need to be true for you to trust an independent review as much as one organised by an established journal?

If you share the concern behind this letter, we invite you to sign it, to join the founding network, and to pass it on to colleagues who care about how science is evaluated. More information, and a short form to express interest, are at <https://sofiagallego.com/peer-review-cooperative/>.

With best regards,

The founding group

Signatories

Names and affiliations of the founding group and first signatories will be listed here.

⁷J.-S. Caux, “SciPost at a crossroads”, May 2025, <https://jscaux.org/blog/post/2025/05/13/scipost-at-a-crossroads/>.

⁸STAT, 18 August 2025, <https://www.statnews.com/2025/08/18/pay-peer-reviewers-allowable-publication-costs-nih-proposal-open-access/>.

⁹Nature, 28 September 2026, <https://www.nature.com/articles/d41586-026-02277-y>.